

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

This text appeared in the author's personal blog page:

TODAY I SAW A FORTUNE TELLER IN HONG KONG...

Fortune telling is one of the oldest professions in the world, and it still plays a critical role in Hong Kong. It's much more a science than you think. Keen to experience the real Hong Kong culture, my friend and I went off to Temple Street and once there decided to go with the palm and face reading. We sat on our plastic stools, bargained the price and got started.

I go first. The only thing the fortune teller asks me is my date of birth. He looks at his books of Chinese zodiac for a moment, then observes my face intensely...

...After a while, he starts describing my life accurately! My job, how I love the outdoors, even my plans for the future. So far I'm quite impressed, he's really getting the details right. This guy is good. He sees that something changed in 2012, I went in a whole new direction in my life – the year I quit my job to travel the world. He didn't ask if I was in a relationship, but he starts describing my husband – a handsome man – and the relationship accurately. He looks at me with a very serious expression and insists: he is not the right man for you.

After fifteen minutes talking, the fortune teller is exhausted. To be honest, so am I. I came just as a curious traveller, and ended up a believer. And worried about my husband!

Your class is doing a project on Hong Kong culture in the 21st century. Your group has been asked to discuss the art of fortune telling. You may want to talk about:

- why people like going to fortune tellers
- why fortune telling is an important part of Chinese culture
- whether fortune telling will remain popular in the modern world
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Would you go to a fortune teller?
2. Do you believe in fortune telling?
3. Do you want to know about your future?
4. What kind of people believe in fortune tellers?
5. Would you like to study fortune telling as a subject?
6. Do you believe some people are born lucky?
7. Do fortune tellers take advantage of people?
8. Should fortune tellers need a licence to practise?